Gold in cultures and traditions

Gold is a colour that people long thought was “obvious”. Worth, power, celebration. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about trade, faith and collecting than about the colour itself**. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how gold is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as a guide. What is verified history and what a later interpretation, I say in each part.

Gold in different cultures

Egypt

The gold funerary mask of Tutankhamun weighs roughly ten kilograms and is inlaid with lapis lazuli, carnelian and glass. In the Egyptian image gold symbolises the divine and the afterlife. The mask shows the king in the form of Osiris, the god of the afterlife.

From a tomb where gold was not meant to tempt but to endure.

Gold here is **an image of immortality**.

Byzantium

In Byzantine icons the gold background is a sign that the scene takes place in heaven. The gold glory, the halo, symbolises according to Orthodox theology the uncreated light. The halo appears in Christian art from the fourth century.

From churches where gold was not about money but about light.

Gold here is **a window into heaven**.

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Japan

Kintsugi repairs broken ceramics with urushi lacquer and powder of gold, silver or platinum. The seams remain visible. The technique is close to the idea of wabi-sabi.

From a tea room where a cracked bowl became a more beautiful bowl.

Gold here is **a trace that says it was treasured**.

California

The gold rush in California began on 24 January 1848, when James Marshall found gold at Sutter's Mill in Coloma. By the end of 1848 about six thousand people had arrived, in 1849 roughly ninety thousand and by 1855 at least three hundred thousand.

From a land where gold attracted more people than any other colour.

Gold here is **a dream that draws whole crowds**.

Gold in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at gold **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and a source of inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional system of five elements yellow is linked with earth, the centre, the spleen and stomach and worries. Metal is the element of white and autumn. Gold is in the tradition often read as yellow with the shine of metal. That is my own reflection, not a classical table.

How it relates to the colour gold. For our story the image can carry the thought that worth needs soil. Gold jewellery is beautiful, but it warms only when you have certainty beneath you. **Gold without support can be just shine.**

And what if I asked you now?

“What is real support for me and what is only decoration?”

The centre and food

The yellow earth is in tradition linked with how we nourish ourselves. A gold table does not feed. A warm and matt gold can feel warming, whereas a sharp and glossy one draws attention. Try to tell apart what does you good.

Autumn and letting go

A golden autumn tree is beautiful and lets its leaves go. **You do not have to choose one position for ever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to the colour gold. In Ayurveda-inspired work we can ask about warmth, shine and heaviness. Gold does not give the same experience in every material. A matt gold fabric and a glossy sheet of metal are rather different worlds.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. A matt and soft gold can feel warming, a sharp shine can irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  Warming without shouting.
- **Beware of shine**
  A sharp contrast can be an extra stimulus.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, and is often cold. Gold in a warm fabric or a candle gives a feeling of home. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Warm gold**
  A candle, honey, a soft fabric.
- **Evening**
  Golden light instead of harsh.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. A gold accent can enliven, but large areas weigh a wall down. **Add movement and light to them.**

- **A small accent**
  A frame or jewellery.
- **A light base**
  Lightens a heavy environment.

We will therefore not make gold a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a particular form brings you comfort or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe gold as a separate colour. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thought, not his statement. In alchemy gold is the goal of the work and Jung read alchemy as an image of inner transformation. In such a reading gold can mean **what has been born in a person after long work**.

How it relates to the colour gold. In symbolic language you can read gold as **the colour of worth that arose from experience**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours to be made into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same gold can be a support for one woman and pressure for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations gold and metallic colours are often assigned to the element of metal and yellow to earth. Schools differ in the assignment, so take it as one of the possibilities.

Gold is like jewellery

A little adds shine to a space, a whole room turns it into a shop window. A gold detail works when there is room to rest around it.

Simple tips

- **Start small**
  A gold frame, candlestick or lamp. A gold frame does not behave like a gold wall.
- **Choose matt**
  A matt gold feels quieter than a glossy one.
- **Give it light**
  Warm light changes gold more than other colours.
- **Give it wood**
  Wood, linen and wool add body.
- **Try it in daylight**
  See how it looks in the morning and in the evening.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a cushion or a larger sample.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH Gold is only a sign of wealth.

TRUTH In many cultures it is also the colour of celebration, holiness and victory. The gold background of icons is often interpreted as light, not as money.

MYTH Gold will turn black over time.

TRUTH Gold does not react with oxygen or with sulphur in the air, unlike silver. That is why the colour gold has long been linked with permanence.

MYTH The more gold, the more luxury.

TRUTH Rather the opposite. A little gold looks refined, a lot feels heavy. One gold detail, such as a frame or a lamp, is often enough.

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What gold works well with

- **Black**
  A festive and firm pair. Watch the quantity.
- **Dark blue**
  A deep and calm contrast that softens gold.
- **Cream**
  Gentler than a sharp white. Gold feels soft in it.
- **Green**
  Bottle green and matt gold are a classic.
- **Brown**
  A warm, earthy impression with shine on top.
- **Red**
  Festive and striking. Watch that they do not pull against each other.

Elements

- **Metal**
  Gold is its natural representative. Watch that it does not dominate.
- **Earth**
  Brown and yellow warm it.
- **Water**
  Dark blue and black deepen it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A gold frame, candlestick or lamp can add a festive detail.

What to watch for. When all the mirrors, frames and candlesticks are gold, the room feels like a shop window.

A simple tip. Leave one more striking piece and calmer materials around it.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Gold taps or bowls can turn a meal into a celebration.

What to watch for. Shine shows fingerprints and ages quickly when it is polished.

A simple tip. Pay attention to the material and maintenance. A matt surface behaves differently from a glossy one.

Bedroom

What works. A gold lamp or a soft fabric can give a room a warming impression.

What to watch for. Glossy surfaces reflect light and can disturb the calm of the evening.

A simple tip. Try a matt and muted gold. Let the light be warm.

Children's room

What works. A gold star, little crown or frame can be play for a child.

What to watch for. A gold wall can become heavy. A child may not want it.

A simple tip. Let the child choose and start with a small detail.

Study

What works. A gold detail on the desk can remind you of what matters to you.

What to watch for. Glossy surfaces around a screen cause reflections.

A simple tip. Leave one accent, mute the rest.

Bathroom

What works. A gold tap or mirror frame can give a warm impression.

What to watch for. Limescale and fingerprints show more on glossy gold than on silver.

A simple tip. Consider a matt finish and diffused light.

And try answering now

“Why do I want gold at home? What is it meant to bring me, warmth, celebration, or recognition?”

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